Shosholoza and Hand-Me-Downs

By Sarah Kay

INTRODUCTION

The year was 1965. The apartheid government swooped into District Six, Cape Town, South Africa, forcibly removing its occupants and declaring the area a "whites-only" zone. The rich fabric of an impoverished but vibrant community was torn to shreds. Over 60, 000 people were wrenched from their homes, livelihoods, community centers and societal networks, and relocated to the bleak plains of the Cape Flats, several kilometers away. District Six in Cape Town posed a threat to the apartheid government, which was intent on enforcing "separate development" for different ethnic groups. Across the ocean, Martin Luther King was leading the Civil Rights march from Selma to Montgomery Alabama.

Shosholoza
(hear pronunciation here
http://www.howtosay.us/pronounce-shosholoza/)
by Sarah Kay

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Shosholoza

**NOTE: This poem begins and ends with the song "Shosholoza," a Ndebele folk song that some hail as the "unofficial" or "second" national anthem of South Africa. It was sung by migrant workers in South African mines as a song of resistance and solidarity. The very rough translation is: Moving fast, moving strong, through these mountains like a rolling train to South Africa. You are leaving, you are leaving though these mountains like a rolling train from Zimbabwe.*

Shosholoza, ku lezontaba stimela siphume South Africa
Wenu yabaleka, ku lezontaba stimela siphume Zimbabwe

Noor Ebrahim had fifty homing pigeons.

He lived in District Six at the center of Cape Town.

Noor Ebrahim lived with fifty pigeons in District Six at the center of Cape Town, where there were twelve schools

and the Holy Cross Church, and the Aspeling Street Mosque

and the Jews on Herrington Street. With the immigrants and

the natives, the Indians and the Malays,

the Blacks and the Coloureds. Noor Ebrahim lived with
fifty pigeons
in District Six at the center of Cape Town, where there
was
Beikinstadt Bookstore and Parker's corner shop; where
you could
buy bread and paraffin for the stove, fish oil, bulls-eyes
and almond rock; where you could walk to the public
baths,
pay a *ticky*, get a fifteen-minute shower, and find
yourself between
the gangsters and the businessmen bathing side-by-side,
right there,
at the corner of Clifton and Hanover Streets.
Nor Ibrahim lived in District Six at the center of Cape
Town
With fifty pigeons and his family.
Now watch.
Take 1 city: Cape Town
Divide it into 12 districts.
Now take one of them, District 6,

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Add 70,000 people over time.
Divide that by the Group Area Act of 1950
and you wind up with what?

I'll give you a hint. It's the same as if you were to divide
by race
So you're left with the remainder of 1 Apartheid
Government
and 1 declaration of 1966 which stated that from now on
District 6
would be officially recognized as a designated whites-
only area.

So no more Handover Street with the thick smell of
curry coming from Dout's café, and no more Janjura's
groceries,
Maxim's sweeterie, Waynik's school uniforms, and the
sound of
children. Shoppers. Merchants. Buses. Laughter. Song.
No.

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At the end of all that, you are left with only bulldozers.
Leveled buildings. Raised land. Broken glass and brick.
Not even phantoms will haunt this ghost town,
because even their floating figures are not white
enough.

Noor Ebrahim moved the ten kilometers to Athlone.
He packed fifty pigeons into their cages and left
District Six
at the center of Cape Town. He left the Peninsula
Maternity Home
where hundreds of coloured babies were born every year
and the soda fountain where you could watch the ladies
bring
their laundry down to the public washhouse three times
a week.
He left his house on Caledon Street.
Noor Ebrahim left his home on Caledon Street in
District Six
at the heart of Cape Town and moved the ten kilometers
to Athlone.

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He lived there for weeks, sometimes driving
past the empty pit of land where District Six no longer
stood.
The winds blew hard, and they swept through the dust
and the dirt
and the broken glass until every blade of grass bent
beneath the weight of what was no longer there.

After three months, the droppings at the bottom of the
birdcages
had become three layers thick. Noor Ebrahim decided it
was time
to let the pigeons fly free -- fly free so they could find
their way back.
He knew that not all of them would return that night.
He knew that the next morning, some of those cages
might not be as full. But he also knew that sometimes,
gravity
can become a little too comfortable.
So that morning, Noor Ebrahim opened the doors on the
cages,

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and the winds that swept through Cape Town swept through and
lifted all fifty pigeons up into the air in a cloud of feathers, as if to say,

It does not matter how long we have been kept in cages.
It does not matter how strong your gravity is.
We were always meant to fly.

That night, Noor Ebrahim returned from work.
He turned off the car, went around to the back of the house, and
cried out in pain. Not a single bird had come back to him.
The cages were lined with droppings and feathers, but no pigeons.
The man who had watched them level his house to the ground
without shedding a single tear, now felt his mind go cloudy and his
ribcage felt as empty as the ones the bird had abandoned.

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He got back into the car to take a drive and clear his mind.

As he drove down the long streets of Cape Town, the wheel moved beneath his hands and he found himself on the abandoned roads of District Six.
And as he reached Caledon Street, Noor Ebrahim slowed to a stop.
Because there on the empty plot of land where his house once stood,
were pigeons. All fifty of them.
Standing amongst the dust and the dirt and the broken glass,
looking up at him as if to say, *Where is our home?*

South Africa. We sing a song of strength.
We go on like a rolling train forever.
We never let gravity become too familiar
Because we were always meant to fly.

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Shosholoza, ku lezontaba stimela siphume South Africa
Wenu yabaleka, ku lezontaba stimela siphume Zimbabwe

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sarah Kay
Book: No Matter the Wreckage
ISBN: 978-1938912481
Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing
Date (Month/Year): March 2014

INTRODUCTION

Apartheid in South Africa, the Civil Rights Movement in the U.S. . . . that was so long ago. Down through the ages racism has been an issue in almost every society.

Many Americans would like to claim that racism doesn't exist anymore . . . not in our country; but the fact of the matter is . . . racism does and will continue to exist not only in America, but throughout the world.

Why? Racism is a tradition that is passed down from one generation to the next – it is the anger spawned by focusing on the negative and seeing only the "differences." Every culture . . . EVERY culture . . . is guilty of harboring some degree of racism – We wear it like . . . .

Hand-Me-Downs by Sarah Kay.

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Hand-Me-Downs

I know you've taken to wearing around your father's
hand-me-down anger. But I wish that you wouldn't.
It's a few sizes too big and everyone can see it doesn't
fit you, makes you look silly, hangs loose at all the wrong
places,
even if it does match your skin color.

I know you think you'll grow into it: that your arms
will beef up after all the fighting and it will sit on your
shoulders if you pin it on the right places with
well-placed conviction.

The bathroom mirror tells you, you look good,
your fists look a lot more justified.
When you dig your hands deep into the pockets,
you'll find stories he left there for you to hand out
to the other boys like car bombs.

On days when everything else is slipping through
your fingers, you can wrap yourself inside of this anger.
This will keep you warm at night, help you drift off to

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sleep
with the certainty that no matter what happens,
it will still be there when you wake up.

The longer you wear it, the better it fits.
Until some of those stories are your own. The holes
in the sleeve are from the bullets you dodged yourself.
When it rips, snags on a barbed wire fence or
someone else's family, don't worry.

Your mother and your sister will mend it:
patch the holes, sew the tears, replace a button or two.
They will help you back into it and tell you how proud
they are of you; how good it looks on you. The same way
it looked on your dad and your granddad, too.

And on his father before him and on his father before him.
But back then? Back then there was only sand. Until someone
drew a line. Someone built a wall. Someone threw a stone.

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And the crack in the skull that it hit fractured
perfectly like twigs on the branches of a family tree, So someone

threw a stone back. And each fracture, each tiny break
wound itself together into thread. The thread pulled itself
around him, your great-great-great-great-somebody.
And on the other side of the wall, they were knitting just as fast and
theirs fit them just as well, only in a slightly different shade.

So I'm asking, when the time comes, who is going be
the first to put down the needle and thread?
Who is going be the first one to remember that
their grandfather suffered just as many broken windows,
broken hearts, broken bones? And the first time

you come down to dinner, and your son is sitting at the
dining room table wearing your hatred on his shoulders,

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who is going to be the first to tell him it is finally time

to take it off?

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